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Our Internal and External Policy[1]

IN view of certain statements made in the British press and reproduced thereafter in the Indian press, which may have led to some misunderstanding of my socio-political views. I desire to say that there has been no fundamental change in my position since I came to Europe. I maintain more strongly than ever that while it is imperatively necessary that we should study all the modern movements abroad, it is equally necessary for us in India to chalk out the future lines of our progress in conformity with our past history and our present and future requirements. The geographical and intellectual isolation which India has enjoyed for centuries should enable us to adopt a sympathetic but critical attitude towards other lands and nations.

It is necessary for us in India to distinguish clearly once for all between our internal and external policy. I am aware that the Indian National Congress has not yet developed its external policy, but if we are sincere about what we talk, we shall have to do so without delay. In the domain of our external policy, our own socio-political views or predilections should not prejudice us against people or nations holding different views, whose sympathy we may nevertheless be able to acquire. This is a universal cardinal principle in external policy and it is because of this principle that to-day in Europe a pact between Soviet Russia and Fascist-Italy is not only a possibility but an accomplished fact. Therefore, in our external policy, we should heartily respond to any sympathy for India which we may find in any part of the world.

In determining our internal policy, it would be a fatal error to say that the choice for India lies between Communism and Fascism. The standpoint or socio-political theories and institutions of the modern nations are the product of their history, environment

[1] Full text of statement issued from Geneva in February, 1935.